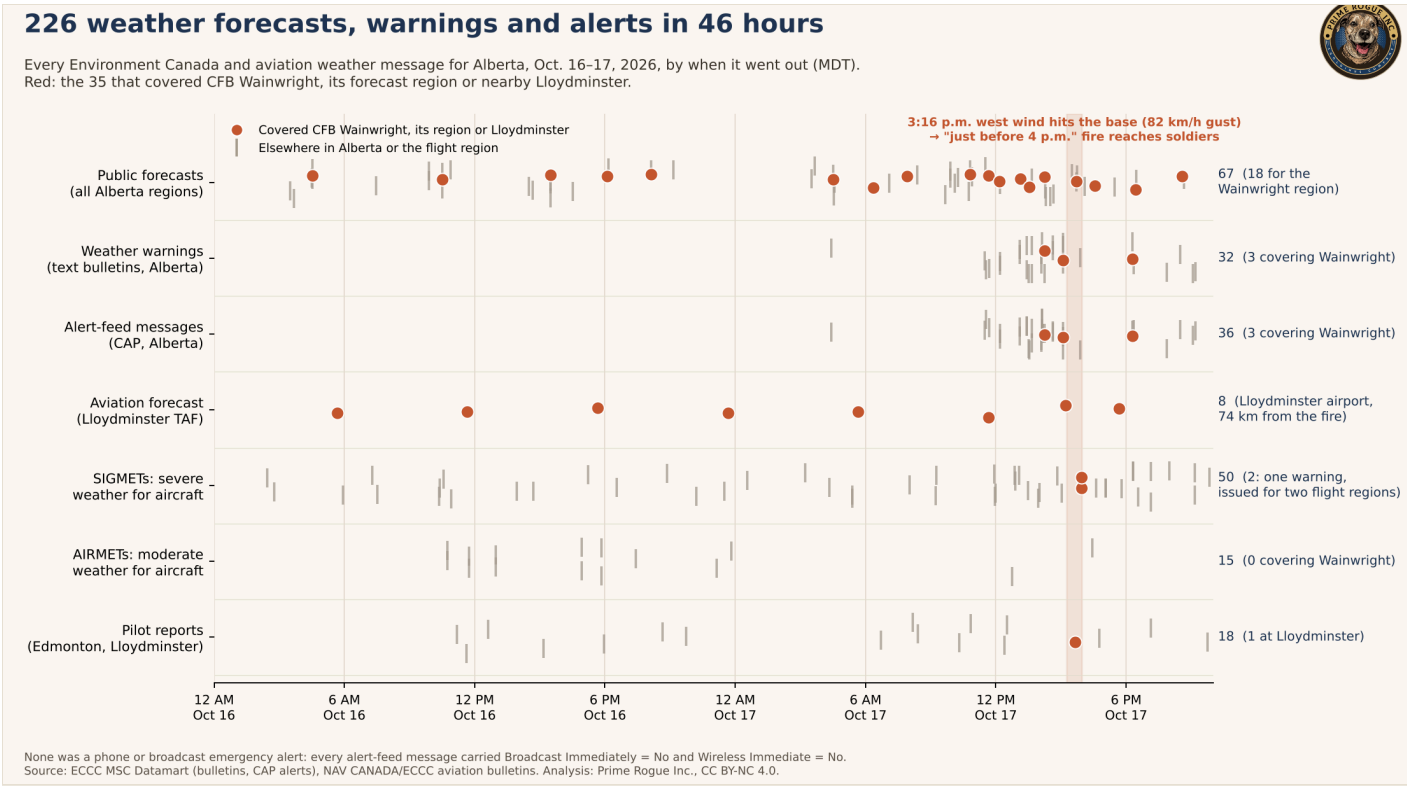
226 weather messages, and none that pushed an alert

Kevin J.S. Duska Jr. · Oct. 29, 2026

I went through every forecast, warning and alert that Environment and Climate Change Canada (ECCC) and the aviation weather system put out for Alberta on Oct. 16 and 17. For each one, I checked whether it covered CFB Wainwright, and whether it was sent as an alert that interrupts phones, TV or radio.

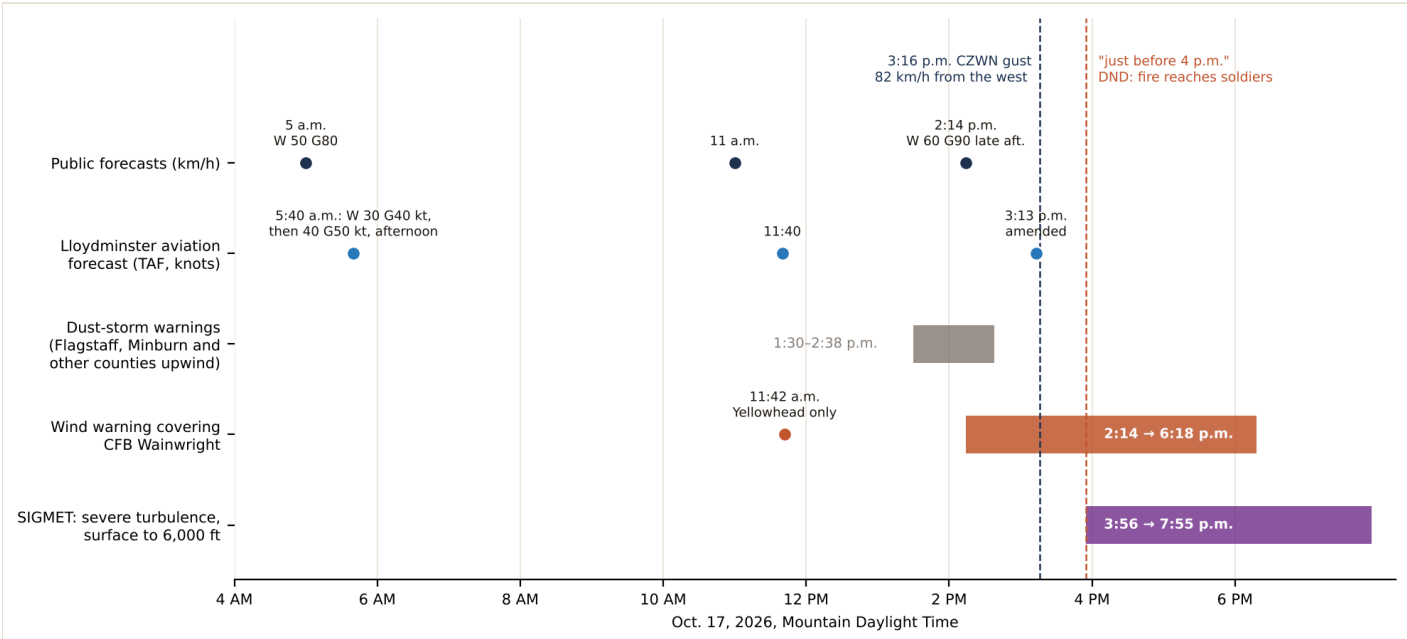
Bottom line

- **Lots of warnings went out.** Between midnight Oct. 16 and 10 p.m. Oct. 17 there were 226 weather messages for Alberta and its airspace. 35 of them covered CFB Wainwright, its forecast region or nearby Lloydminster.
- **Nothing pushed an emergency alert.** All 36 alert-feed messages for Alberta in that window, including the three wind-warning messages that covered the base, were flagged *Broadcast Immediately: No* and *Wireless Immediate: No*. None of them would have sounded on phones, or interrupted TV or radio, through the national Alert Ready system.
- **The base was under a wind warning from 2:14 p.m.** The pairs range, Range 15 and the CZWN airfield all fall inside the warning areas from 2:14 p.m. until it ended at 6:18 p.m. That's about an hour and a half before DND says the fire reached the soldiers "just before 4 p.m."
- **The aviation side was blunter.** At 5:40 a.m., the aviation forecast (TAF) for Lloydminster airport, 74 km from the fire, called for west winds of 30 knots gusting 40 by mid-afternoon, then 40 gusting 50 (about 74 gusting 93 km/h). At 3:56 p.m., a SIGMET (a warning to all aircraft) for **severe turbulence from the surface to 6,000 ft** was issued along a line that ran within about 1 nautical mile of the pairs range.



Every ECCC and aviation weather message for Alberta, Oct. 16–17, by the time it went out (MDT). Red marks the ones covering CFB Wainwright, its forecast region or Lloydminster.

Oct. 17, product by product



Product	What it said, and when (MDT)	Covered the base?	Pushed as an emergency alert?
Public forecast, Lloydminster – Wainwright – Vermilion – Provost (km/h)	Every issue from 5 a.m. Oct. 16 called for the afternoon west wind. On Oct. 17 the bulletin was issued or amended 13 times: 5 a.m. "west 50 gusting to 80 this afternoon"; 2:14 p.m. "west 60 gusting to 90 late this afternoon."	**Yes (forecast region)**	**No: published for people to look up**
Wind warning (text bulletin and alert feed)	11:42 a.m.: Yellowhead corridor only. **2:14 p.m.: extended to the Wainwright region**, "gusts up to 100 km/h ... this afternoon," confidence high. 3:05 p.m.: updated. 6:18 p.m.: ended.	**Yes, from 2:14 p.m.**	**No (Broadcast Immediately: No)**
Dust-storm warnings	1:30–2:38 p.m. for Flagstaff, Minburn, Beaver, Camrose and other counties to the west and north-west, upwind of Wainwright.	No	**No**
Aviation forecast (TAF), Lloydminster airport (knots)	5:40 a.m.: west 30 gusting 40 kt from 2–3 p.m., becoming 290° 40 gusting 50 kt by 5 p.m. Reissued 11:40 a.m.; amended 3:13 p.m.	Nearby (74 km)	Aviation channels only
SIGMET A7 / H1 (Edmonton and Winnipeg flight regions)	3:56 p.m., valid to 7:55 p.m.: severe turbulence forecast from the surface to 6,000 ft within a 50 NM-wide band from 25 NM north of Lloydminster to near Hanna, moving south-east at 40 kt.	**Yes (pairs range ≈1 NM from the line)**	Aviation channels only
Pilot report, Lloydminster	3:37 p.m.: a Cessna Citation Mustang reported moderate turbulence at 7,000 ft.	Nearby	Aviation channels only
AIRMETs; ECCC MetNotes; air-quality forecasts	No AIRMET for the area. No Prairie MetNotes on Oct. 16–17. No air-quality forecast for Wainwright.	No	n/a

What "pushed" means here

ECCC's warnings go out on a national alert feed, in a format called CAP. Each message carries flags that tell broadcasters and wireless carriers whether to interrupt programming or sound phones through Alert Ready. On Oct. 16–17, every Alberta weather alert had both flags set to **No**. These were yellow, "moderate impact" warnings. They reached people who went looking: weather.gc.ca, the WeatherCAN app (for users who'd saved the area and turned on notifications), and media and apps that carry the feed.

Aviation products (TAFs, SIGMETs, pilot reports) go to pilots and flight services through NAV CANADA's channels, not to the public.

What I don't know yet

- Which of these, if any, range control or the troops on the pairs range received, and when. I've put that to DND, with a deadline of 5 p.m. MT on Oct. 29.
- What the military's own weather service (CFWOS) forecast for the base. Those forecasts aren't public, and the airfield (CZWN) has no civilian aviation forecast in the public feed.
- Whether Alberta Emergency Alert, the province's separate system, issued anything. I'm still checking that.

Method

I downloaded every ECCC alert-feed (CAP) file for the Prairie storm centre (CWWG) dated Oct. 16–18. Oct. 16 had none for Alberta. I also downloaded every text bulletin of the relevant types: public forecasts, warnings, aviation forecasts (TAF), SIGMETs, AIRMETs,

pilot reports, air quality and marine. That came to 2,741 files from ECCC's MSC Datamart. I tested each CAP warning polygon against the pairs range (52.7695 N, 110.9005 W), Range 15 and the CZWN airfield, and read the SIGMET line coordinates against the same points. The timeline counts messages from midnight Oct. 16 to 10 p.m. Oct. 17 MDT. French-language duplicates are excluded. The full event list (226 rows) and the parsed alert flags are available on request.

Sources

- Wind warning covering Wainwright, alert feed: 2:14 p.m. · 3:05 p.m. · 6:18 p.m. (ended). Text bulletin: 2:14 p.m.
- Earlier warnings: 11:42 a.m. Yellowhead wind · 1:30 p.m. dust storm · 2:06 p.m. dust storm
- Public forecasts: 5 a.m. Oct. 16 · 5 a.m. Oct. 17 · 2:14 p.m. Oct. 17
- Lloydminster TAF: 5:40 a.m. · 3:13 p.m. amended
- SIGMETs: A7, Edmonton · H1, Winnipeg. Pilot report: Lloydminster, 3:37 p.m.

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